German-style cheese soups are often flavored with beer, sometimes using lager or pilsner. This version uses wheat beer, and is thick and rich with a good blend of flavors.

emmental and beer soup

SERVES 6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 30 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

2 tbsp butter
2 onions, finely chopped
1 clove garlic, chopped
⅓ cup flour
3¼ cups chicken stock
⅔ cup German wheat beer
5½oz (150g) Emmental, finely grated
5½oz (150g) Gruyère, finely grated
freshly ground white pepper
1 tbsp fresh thyme leaves, to serve

1 Melt the butter over low heat in a large, heavy pan. Add the onion and garlic and sauté for 10 minutes until soft but not colored. Gradually stir in the flour, then add the stock a little at a time, stirring constantly until smooth. Bring to a boil, then simmer for 10 minutes or until the liquid begins to thicken slightly. Stir regularly to be sure the mixture doesn't start to stick to the pan, then add the wheat beer and return to a gentle boil.

2 Remove from the heat and very gradually add the two cheeses, adding a handful at a time and stirring constantly. Season to taste with pepper, pour into warm soup bowls, and top with fresh thyme. Serve with German bread and beer.